

No dearth of drama ahead of Ranji knockouts

The Ranji Trophy's league stage witnessed some **majestic individual performances** and nerve-racking close matches.



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Reputations were reinforced and legacies revived as the group stage of the Ranji Trophy Elite division wound to a close after over a month-and-a-half of action.

Under the full-time leadership of left-arm spinner R. Sai Kishore, **Tamil Nadu witnessed a turnaround in its red-ball cricket fortunes when it booked its first quarterfinal berth since the 2016-17 season.** The wait for five-time champion Baroda was even longer as it snapped a nine-season-long absence in the knockouts phase of the tournament.

Vidarbha topped Group A to qualify for the last-eight stage for the first time since its victorious season in 2018-19, while Mumbai was back to asserting its dominance after a rare blip in 2022-23.

Meanwhile, it was business as usual for Saurashtra, which rode on

stalwart Cheteshwar Pujara's 781 runs in 11 innings, even as skipper Jaydev Unadkat had an underwhelming season with the ball, to continue its quest for a third title in four seasons.

In a hat tip to the defending champion's aura of invincibility,



Devdutt Padikkal of Karnataka is in stellar form this season, having piled up 556 runs in six innings at an average of 92.66, including three hundreds.